

ALIGNED

Lead with Love, Live with Intention

CHAPTER ONE

Grieving a Ghost — The Person You're Mourning Never Existed

You hear the dreaded words; your stomach falls through the floor. Your chest tightens; you stop listening, trying to process what is actually happening. Everything in your body becomes hollow, and you feel the tears rushing to exit your eyes. While tears fall, everything in your body loses energy, and it feels like the world just came crashing down right on top of you. The hardest part of a relationship. When we get into them, we never think about the inevitable until it arrives. The person you are imagining a future with and ready to walk through life with has just slipped through your fingers. The heartbreak is terrible, and it's not a bad thing if you have to grieve to heal yourself back up into the person you were the day before the breakup. Healing is a good part of heartbreak because it gives you many lessons throughout your life, and everything happens for a reason. Some people are heartbroken over someone whom they only met for a month, or never even made a move. Whether it was on a dating app, and you thought the date was going smoothly. Then one day, out of nowhere, you never hear a text back from them. We can be heartbroken when someone we like gets into another relationship, but in reality, if they get into a relationship with someone else in your fingertips, they were not looking at you as an option or not the right one in the moment. So we grieve. Through lonely nights, where you sit alone, playing back all the memories that you once had with them. If it were someone you had been talking to for one month, maybe you are playing your future repeatedly in a what-if scenario. Heartbreak is hard to control because emotions can take over, and the text that you shouldn't have sent is now in their phone. Having the mindset of "I don't care anymore about this person," but if you're texting them, then you are casting your last hook for attention.

I can't just type this page and say that heartbreak is not something you should cry over. The void is now just sitting in your life, and your life has just been completely flipped upside down. Imagine you are running a race, and

then suddenly you roll your ankle and you can't run anymore. Like relationships, you are running through life with this person, and one step later, they are not even there anymore. You cannot continue the race until you heal your ankle. With one foot, you can slowly proceed to completing the race, which is what people with heartbreak do; they make it through long days even if they have little to give, until they heal again. When we think of heartbreak, what do we normally think about?

I want you to think about that question for a minute. Heartbreak and grieving over the loss of someone is what we normally think of. When we grieve over the heartbreak, we are actually grieving over the thing that we thought it was. The partner that you thought would be your first kid's mother/father, obviously, now you know this person will not be that. When we are grieving, we normally don't grieve over the person, but the many experiences of how they made us feel, and now knowing what we thought was going to be a lifetime is now gone in the snap of a finger. The person you got to know for one month made you feel special. You saw some spark, and now you are dreaming about your future together. Then they ghost you. That heartbreak is grieving over what you thought was going to be, so understand that we are not grieving over the loss of the person. You're not missing them, you're missing the version you made in your head. You're not missing them, you're missing the future you built inside your own mind. You're not missing them, you're missing the way you felt thinking it was true love. You're not missing them, you're missing the fantasy of love you thought you were in. Remember, heartbreak will take time, some longer than others, but understand what you are actually heartbroken over. Most of the time, it's not the person; it's the version you created in your head. In reality, it was never them.

How are we able to navigate through a breakup? The initial shock when the other person mentions they want to go their separate ways. There are many people who react to this differently. Some people try to plead their case to keep the relationship intact. Which I think is a terrible idea. The other person is walking out the door of your life, so what makes you think they are going to stay even longer, and if they do, a lifetime? We think of relationships as two people choosing each other. They chose you at one moment, but now are trying to take back their decision. They are not choosing you anymore as someone they want to fight for in their life. The priorities they have changed. When they stopped fighting for your love is the biggest red flag waving through the air. They didn't decide five minutes before the conversation; they decided through

constant fights in their own head on whether or not they wanted to stay. Let them walk out of your life; they're already one foot out the door. Don't fight for something that you think you want. Then we get those who are so heartbroken that they decide to text the other person, maybe after a couple of hours. Trying to get that final say to see if they can come back into your life. This isn't a moment where you are missing the person who just walked out of your life; this is you fearing what loneliness is going to feel like. You don't want to go back into a world where you don't have someone by your side. So you do whatever it takes to keep this person. You are acting solely on emotions and fear in this situation and not letting yourself fully embrace the reality that is about to set in: loneliness. This phase will be the hardest part to emotionally overcome during the heartbreak: the first couple of hours, or that first night where you wake up and it still doesn't feel real, but it is. You are now in a world where you are single. Getting through that initial shock will be the hardest part; your nervous system doesn't want the change, but once it fully accepts it, then the remaining healing will be a little easier. Now, we are past the initial shock, and this person is officially gone. The void is now entering their lives.

The main thing I realized during this time was the void it caused me. Throughout a relationship, you have this piece that you offer to them. Texting how they are, hanging out with the person, telling them all your jokes, and telling them the drama at work between two people. When a relationship ends, it leaves you with a large void that is no longer filled by your partner. Who can you vent to, tell your crazy conspiracy theories to, or just lay down after a long day and watch a movie with? All those moments were filling a piece of you. The strange part is that your partner had quietly become most of your daily life. Now you have to navigate without someone you solely relied on each day. You now feel days are longer than ever; your phone texts are officially done for, and your day feels very uneventful. It's only you now. Trying to fill in this void was the hardest part, and although today I fill that void with some other things, just like this passage I am writing, I still have some of me that is ready to be filled. Am I leaving it open just in case I can find someone someday, maybe?

Coping with the void in your life is hard. First, accept the fact that this person is not the right choice for you. You may have put them so high in your life, but let me ask you a question. How can someone who does not choose you be the right person for you? It's a great question to ask because they choose you at some point, and they made you feel seen and heard, but as time slowly faded, the affection that they once saw in you is drifting away into the sunset until one day the sun sets. The question is the one I always ask people going

through a breakup. They thought it was something different; they realized it's not. Now, they are acting on their gut. Accepting the outcome of their choice is the first step in filling the void because you can't heal if you are constantly stuck in the past. You must face reality and realize that they are not who we made them out to be. Once you accept this, then you can start filling your cup.

I remember seeing this video of a professor taking a bucket and filling it with golf balls. He asked the class, "Is this bucket full?" Obviously, the class said yes because they were thinking of adding another golf ball into the bucket. Then the professor took out some marbles and filled the bucket with more stuff. "Is this bucket full?" he asks again, repeatedly. He keeps doing this with rocks, sand, water, and whatever fits into the bucket. Think of your life as this bucket with golf balls, marbles, rocks, etc. Let's say we decide to put the sand in first. Then the rocks, then so on and so forth. We won't be able to fit as many golf balls or marbles into this bucket. We want to adjust our lives in order to fit as much as we can into our bucket. The golf balls are the big things in life. Our family, dreams, etc. and everything else are the smaller things: your hobbies and activities. Finding the balance of friends, family, hobbies, and everyday activities is important. Having a good balance will help us overcome the void that might hit in our lives. Leaving us to a happier and more fulfilled life rather than one that can feel repetitive and boring. At the beginning of a breakup, we will see a void in our life that is wide open, and you can do anything you want within this unknown part of your life. Are you planning to use this extra time you now have to do something you love and that brings you happiness, or keep thinking of hypothetical scenarios, beating yourself up because you are not enough?

When people break up, this is normally the first thing they ask themselves. How was I not enough for this person? What did I do that caused them to think this way? These things will go through the person's head. In reality, the person who broke up with the other had already decided days or months before it actually happened, and just didn't communicate what was getting them to think this way. Sometimes the relationship actually just won't work out, and one side of the party realizes that. Trying to imagine a future, and your current boyfriend or girlfriend isn't even in the image. The problem here isn't anything the person did, but just the vibe and compatibility aren't the same. Then the breakup happens and leaves the person spiraling about how they are not enough.

It's tough when this happens because one day you think everything is going well. You're planning your future with this person, planning what you want to eat for dinner, where you want the wedding to be, and these future scenarios. Only for it all to come crashing down in just one conversation. Feels like someone just dropped a grenade on your whole life and just walked away from everything. Why getting broken up with is hard: not only do you get this void, you don't get the closure that you may have needed. You ask yourself who you are and why you weren't enough. Then, through it all, you have no one to answer the questions for you; all the answers are within your own mind. We know the answers we form are never the actual answers; it's some over-thought scenario that played in our head. Sometimes you can't even get the answers, or you get too many answers, so you can't decide which one to stick with. During this time, it is very easy to spiral out and lose all desire for a relationship.

The way we talk to ourselves can be hard. We see our every flaw, our every decision, and we live in our own heads 24/7. The only person you will be with from the day you were born to the day you pass away is yourself. All of us are sitting through the lonely hours, the good times, the panic attacks, and the constant battles that play in your own head. Perhaps people always label you as the one with a bright smile who cares for others. When deep down you know the battles and moments that shape you into who you are. You know yourself better than anyone can see from the outside. Building that inner self-awareness can be a challenging and long process, but in the end, it is much needed for self-love. I will go into more about this later.

Many people in life will have periods where they may have felt lonely. The only thing that it seems they want is a relationship with a person. Moments like these could go one of two ways. The person can sit there and understand the genuine emotions that they are going through. Find out what they love, how they are hard to handle, what type of boundaries they want in their next relationship, and many other traits they could ask themselves. As in almost anything, there are two sides to a coin. Some people will rush into their next relationship for the fact of not embracing loneliness, running from their own thoughts and emotions. They have someone who can fill that void in their life. Watch out for these people when looking for your next partner. If someone is too scared to live by themselves, then how can they be capable of another relationship? For me, I have been trying to figure out all the emotions and habits that could make me a better partner in my next relationship.

Now that we are alone, we have ourselves to depend on. It's a tough spot to be in because it feels like everyone around you is just going about their day while you sit there fighting yourself about where you're currently at in your life. You're one of the roughly 1 in 5 people who feel this way; you are not the exception you think you are. Everyone has to go through this phase; some build themselves back up, some sit with their feelings and understand them, and some people will rush into another relationship for the cheap dopamine. The last point is the thing I do not want you to do. Do not get into another relationship until you know you are ready yourself. If you fear being alone and you are going into a relationship based on that fear, research tells us a couple of things that happen. The first thing is that you settle for less than you deserve. People think this person in front of them is the only person who will come into their life, or maybe even this other person is way out of their league. So they settle. The second thing that happens when you enter relationships in this stage is that you become dependent on them out of fear of being alone. You start to not be yourself in the relationship and instead start doing what this other person wants you to do, people-pleasing. Think of someone trying to ride a bike. The person will never let you take the training wheels off, and that is your life for the rest of time. This situation molds you to this person's standards instead of your own, which can later on in life affect your mental health. All of us in life want to set out and do things that excite us.

A couple of years or months down the road, this relationship is now what it didn't seem like it was when you were alone. Research indicates that you will fear leaving them, a third outcome of entering a relationship because of the fear of solitude. You're staying in this relationship for the same reason that makes you not want to end it. The fear of loneliness. The thought of being with this person is better than the thought of being alone. Imagine you are building a Lego set. You are already halfway done with the build when you realize you misplaced one piece, making the LEGO look dysfunctional and weird. Are you going to take everything apart and fix that one piece so it can become just like the picture on the box, or are you just going to leave it and let it look off? It's the same thing. Think of your love life as this LEGO. You want it to be just like the picture on the box, but you need to put in the work to break it all down and restart. Even though you've made so much progress on the build, there is no chance that you can complete the structure to look correct unless you restart. To do it all over again, but this time building the structure right. When going through this stage of your love life, remember that loneliness is a scary place to be, but we must go back into the unknown and understand who we are before

we can finish the puzzle the correct way.

I want to share with you some things I learned about myself throughout this time. First things first, when I first had my breakup, I had a moment where I wanted to show this person what they were missing. Going to the gym seven times a week, trying to gain as much muscle mass as possible, and trying to run every day. I started the 75 Hard challenge a day after the breakup. If you don't know what that is, it's a workout program that transforms your current self in the matter of 75 days. I was the one who broke up with them. I was the one who wasn't ready for a relationship, and I acted like someone had just broken up with me. Basically, I'm trying to be the next David Goggins. But in reality, this had its own downfall. I never enjoyed the stuff; I just had that motivation that pushed me through the early workouts and the two-a-days I was doing in the gym until my tank ran empty. Many people will go through this phase right after a breakup. It's normal. You have that motivation that can push you farther than you thought you could; I say you should use that. With this motivation, you try to show the other person who you can be, rather than being that person before the relationship broke up. This mindset will soon fizzle out. A big opening point for who I was becoming was this breakup.

Everyone is going to have a different timeline with heartbreak. Maybe it was someone you spent half your life with; getting over that is not just going to take two days. Much of our life has now changed, and we are adapting to what life currently is, not what we thought it was. Don't think that there is a certain timeline for getting over a heartbreak. That doesn't mean obsessing over them for months and months, but just trying little things to slowly guide you back to the version of yourself that didn't rely on this other person. Some days it might be hard to get out of bed, but you get up anyway. That is one step closer to getting your spark back. When you are healing, the healing process might seem complete when you are no longer ever thinking about them anymore. That is wrong. You will know you are healed when you can think about this person and control your emotions about them. Not going through a constant spiral, or getting fueled up with anger because you hate this person. It could be something like seeing a billboard they pointed out, their favorite restaurant that they always raved about, or even their favorite song in the car that plays. You once loved someone who was attached to these things. Just pretending that they no longer exist is running away from your emotions, instead of facing them head-on. You never heal that way. Understanding what emotions flow through your body when they pop up is what will get you to heal from the void they put into your life. Over time, you will start labeling things you once loved

with other events that may have happened, but until you can do that, they will always pop up, and we have to learn how to control ourselves when these moments spark.

Now you are learning how to heal, starting healing, or maybe even being fully healed from your past. I say that once you heal, a very dangerous moment unfolds right in front of your eyes. The term we all use is loneliness. The art of being alone with no one to talk to and fill our lives. Even if you absolutely love yourself, we are humans who crave interaction. We have friends, family, or other people who can fill that void, but they can only get you so far. Having a wonderful system of friends behind you makes this stage bearable because you have an outlet when times get tough, someone to talk to when you're feeling lonely. If you have someone like this in your life, make sure they understand how much they mean to you, because it is rare to get someone who you are comfortable enough to let out your emotions, and they can sit there and understand everything you are going through. No matter how close and emotionally connected you are with a friend or family you will still have those moments where loneliness sets in. The notifications that you were used to every day are now nonexistent, the funny joke that you heard at work you now have no one to tell, or the stressful day that you had at work just sits inside you, and you can't tell your partner about. Your world is empty at some parts of the day. You have healed from your past, and now you have no one in this current moment of your life, so it is very easy to get attached to someone too quickly who shows you the smallest amount of attention. That craving was never really about them. It was that voice inside your head; the one that got louder the second they walked away, telling you maybe you weren't enough after all. You don't quiet that voice by replacing the person. You quiet it by becoming someone you'd actually choose.